

Reading Momentum

Project goal documentation

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1. Project Overview

Reading Momentum is a social reading platform designed to help people build a consistent reading habit with their friends while allowing every user to read their own book.

The platform is not designed to replace traditional book clubs, Goodreads, or personal reading trackers. It solves a different problem. Many people want to read more, but they lose consistency because reading often lacks structure, accountability, and immediate social reinforcement. Reading Momentum creates that structure without forcing everyone into the same book or the same pace.

The core idea is simple:

Users read what they want, track progress in a low-pressure way, answer thoughtful discussion prompts, interact with friends, earn progress-based rewards, and slowly build a visible reading identity.

The product should feel supportive, personal, and motivating. It should never make reading feel like homework.

2. Problem Statement

Many people want to become regular readers, but they struggle to stay consistent.

The issue is not always access to books. The issue is usually attention, motivation, routine, and follow-through. Reading competes with apps, streaming, social media, work, school, and daily responsibilities. A person may start a book with excitement, read for a few days, lose momentum, and then restart weeks later with a different book.

Existing reading products usually focus on one main behavior:

Tracking finished books

Reviewing books

Joining traditional book clubs

Creating reading statistics

Discovering popular books

These products are useful, but they do not fully address the habit problem. They often track what a user has already done rather than helping the user keep going.

Reading Momentum is built around the belief that people need a better system for reading consistently. That system should combine personal choice, small goals, social accountability, meaningful reflection, and balanced rewards.

3. Product Vision

Reading Momentum will become a platform where friends help each other read more consistently, even when everyone is reading different books.

The long-term vision is to create the best product for social reading accountability. The product should help users finish more books, discuss ideas more often, and develop a stronger personal relationship with reading.

The platform should support multiple types of readers:

Casual readers who read slowly but consistently

Fast readers who finish books quickly

Audiobook listeners

Academic readers

Nonfiction readers

Fiction readers

Manga and graphic novel readers

Deep readers who annotate and reflect

Weekend readers who read in longer sessions

The product should not treat one reading style as superior. Instead, it should reward consistency, effort, reflection, and completion in a balanced way.

4. Target Users

The primary users are people who already want to read more but need accountability and structure.

The initial audience should focus on:

College students

Young professionals

Friend groups

Remote friend groups

Casual readers

People trying to reduce passive screen time

People who like self-improvement apps

People who enjoy books but dislike formal book clubs

The product may later expand to:

Schools

Libraries

Professional learning groups

Corporate book clubs

Creator-led reading communities

Public reading circles

The first version should stay focused on small private groups because trust and comfort matter. Users are more likely to participate when they know the people seeing their progress and responses.

5. Core Product Principles

5.1 User Choice Comes First

Users should choose their own books, formats, goals, and pace.

This matters because motivation tends to last longer when people feel ownership over their choices. A required group book can work for traditional book clubs, but it can also create pressure, guilt, and drop-off when one person falls behind.

Reading Momentum should encourage shared accountability without removing individual freedom.

Product decision:

Users can join the same group while reading different books.

Users can optionally participate in a shared Book of the Month.

Users can skip the group book without being punished.

Users can set reading goals by pages, chapters, minutes, or sessions.

5.2 Consistency Matters More Than Raw Volume

The platform should reward repeated reading behavior more than one-time reading bursts.

A user who reads 15 minutes five days per week is building a stronger habit than a user who reads once for several hours and disappears. However, long reading sessions should still matter. The scoring system should reward both consistency and volume while preventing any single behavior from dominating.

Product decision:

The main score should prioritize weekly consistency.

Long reads should earn bonus progress with diminishing returns.

Streaks should include grace days to avoid discouraging users after one missed day.

5.3 Reflection Improves the Reading Experience

Reading should not only be measured by pages completed. Users should also process what they read.

The app should ask questions that help users notice themes, characters, ideas, emotions, predictions, and opinions. These prompts should help users become more attentive readers.

Product decision:

The app should generate reflection prompts after check-ins.

Prompts should be spoiler-aware.

Prompts should encourage original thought instead of summaries.

Users should be able to answer short or long form.

5.4 Accountability Should Feel Supportive

The app should avoid shame-based motivation.

Users should not feel embarrassed for reading slowly. They should feel encouraged when they show up. Leaderboards and points should support participation, not create unhealthy comparison.

Product decision:

Leaderboards should avoid ranking users only by pages read.

The app should highlight categories like consistency, discussion, support, completion, and comeback progress.

Users should receive recognition for encouraging others.

5.5 The App Should Increase Reading, Not Replace It

The product should not become another attention trap.

The goal is not to maximize screen time. The goal is to increase real reading behavior.

Product decision:

Check-ins should be fast.

Notifications should be useful and limited.

The app should use weekly rituals instead of constant engagement loops.

The dashboard should guide users back to reading.

6. Core Feature Set

6.1 User Accounts and Profiles

Each user needs an account and reading profile.

Profile information should include:

Name

Profile photo

Current books

Completed books

Favorite genres

Reading streak

Reading Momentum score

Achievements

Recent reviews

Reading history

Discussion history

The profile should act as a personal reading identity. It should feel like a living record of a user's reading life.

Reason:

Profiles create ownership. They also make progress visible. Visible progress helps users feel that their effort is accumulating.

6.2 Private Reading Groups

Users should create or join private groups.

A group should include:

Members

Group reading feed

Weekly check-ins

Discussion posts

Book nominations

Book of the Month voting

Group leaderboard

Group reading goals

Reason:

Small groups create social accountability. Users are more likely to return when friends can see their progress and responses.

6.3 Current Book Tracking

Each user should add one or more current books.

The book entry should include:

Title

Author

Format

Genre

Total pages or total chapters when available

Current page or chapter

Reading goal type

Start date

Optional target finish date

Reason:

Users need a simple way to make reading progress visible. Progress tracking also allows the app to generate better prompts and calculate fairer scores.

6.4 Reading Check-Ins

A check-in is the core habit action.

Users should be able to log:

Pages read

Chapters completed

Minutes read

Audiobook minutes listened

Reading session completed

Skipped today

The check-in should take less than 30 seconds.

Reason:

Small actions reduce friction. A user should be able to maintain the habit even on a busy day.

6.5 Monday and Thursday Discussion Rhythm

The app should use a predictable weekly rhythm.

Suggested structure:

Monday: progress check-in and light reflection

Thursday: discussion prompt and group conversation

Weekend: recap, review prompts, and optional Book of the Month voting

Reason:

A weekly rhythm creates structure without making the app feel demanding. Monday and Thursday give users two moments of accountability each week while still allowing flexibility.

6.6 AI Discussion Questions

The app should generate personalized questions based on the user's book, progress, and reading format.

Question types may include:

Character reflection

Theme analysis

Prediction

Personal connection

Argument or critique

Favorite moment

Confusing moment

Emotional reaction

The app should avoid giving answers or summaries unless the user specifically asks for help. The default AI role is to prompt thinking, not replace reading.

Reason:

Reflection prompts increase engagement and help users read with intention. They also make discussion possible even when users are reading different books.

6.7 Group Feed

The group feed should show meaningful activity.

Examples:

A user checked in

A user answered a prompt

A user finished a book

A user posted a review

A user nominated a book

A user reached a streak milestone

The feed should not overload users with every small action.

Reason:

The feed makes the group feel alive. It also creates social reinforcement without requiring constant messaging.

6.8 Comments and Replies

Users should reply to discussion posts, reviews, and milestones.

The app should support:

Short replies

Reactions

Encouragement

Spoiler-safe comments

Threaded discussion

Reason:

The social value of the app comes from conversation. Replies help users feel seen and make reading more interactive.

6.9 Review System

The review system should include both live reviews and final reviews.

Live reviews allow users to record thoughts while reading.

Examples:

Chapter 4 reaction

Mid-book prediction

Favorite quote

Confusing section

Character opinion

Final reviews happen after completion.

A final review should include:

Overall rating

Optional category ratings

Short review

Long review

Recommended audience

Favorite moment

Pacing rating

Writing rating

Character rating

Emotional impact rating

Re-read potential

Reason:

Most reviews are written after a book is finished, which can miss how the reader's opinion changed over time. Live reviews create a more authentic reading timeline.

6.10 Spoiler-Aware Review Timeline

Reviews and comments should respect reading progress.

If one user has reached Chapter 5, they should not automatically see another user's Chapter 20 thoughts.

Spoiler content should be:

Hidden

Blurred

Locked until progress is reached

Clearly labeled

Reason:

Spoilers reduce trust. A spoiler-aware system makes users more comfortable posting honest thoughts while reading.

6.11 Book of the Month

Groups should have an optional Book of the Month system.

The system should allow members to nominate books. The app can then select finalists using a weighted system.

Possible weighting factors:

Number of nominations

Number of votes

Genre fit for the group

Time since last nomination

Past group interest

Positive reviews from group members

Randomness to avoid always picking the most obvious book

The group votes on finalists.

No user should be required to read the winner.

Reason:

This gives the group a shared experience without removing individual reading freedom.

6.12 Balanced Scoring System

The app should use three separate progression systems:

Reading Momentum

XP

Mastery

Reading Momentum should represent current consistency and engagement.

XP should reward actions and unlock cosmetic or profile rewards.

Mastery should track long-term accomplishments.

This separation prevents one score from trying to do everything.

Reason:

Different readers should have different ways to feel successful. A slow consistent reader, a fast finisher, and a deep reflective reader should all see progress.

6.13 Reading Momentum

Reading Momentum should be the main weekly score.

It should reward:

Reading consistency

Recent check-ins

Discussion participation

Reflection quality

Reading volume with diminishing returns

Comeback behavior after missed days

It should not reward unlimited page volume in a linear way.

Reason:

Momentum reflects whether a user is actively maintaining a reading habit. It should not simply measure who read the most pages.

6.14 XP System

XP should reward positive actions.

Example XP categories:

Reading check-in

Discussion response

Reply to a friend

Book completion

Review submission

Book nomination

Streak milestone

Weekly comeback

XP should unlock:

Profile themes

Badges

Achievement displays

Bookshelf customization

Group titles

Reason:

XP gives users short-term reward. It should make progress feel fun without becoming the only reason to read.

6.15 Achievements

Achievements should recognize different reading identities.

Examples:

First Check-In

First Book Finished

7-Day Reader

Weekend Reader

Discussion Starter

Supportive Friend

Deep Reader

Audiobook Listener

Genre Explorer

Review Writer

Comeback Reader

Reason:

Achievements make users feel recognized for different behaviors. This avoids building the app only for fast readers.

6.16 Fair Leaderboards

Leaderboards should focus on multiple categories.

Recommended categories:

Most Consistent

Most Reflective

Most Supportive

Most Improved

Most Books Finished

Longest Current Streak

Best Comeback

Most Active Discussion

Avoid making total pages the main leaderboard.

Reason:

A page-only leaderboard is unfair across genres and formats. It favors short, fast books and can discourage slower readers.

7. Scoring Philosophy

The scoring system must be fair across different reading styles.

The app should recognize that different formats require different effort.

A 20-page research paper is not the same as 20 pages of a graphic novel.

One hour of audiobook listening is still reading.

A slow reader should not be punished for reading dense material.

A fast reader should still be rewarded for finishing quickly.

The proposed scoring system should use normalization and diminishing returns.

Suggested score pillars:

Consistency: 40%

Volume: 20%

Reflection: 20%

Community: 10%

Completion: 10%

This balance makes consistency the core behavior while still rewarding long reads, thoughtful discussion, social participation, and finishing books.

Volume should have diminishing returns.

Example:

A short session earns meaningful credit.

A longer session earns more credit.

A very long session earns additional credit, but not enough to overpower the entire system.

Reason:

This prevents binge reading from dominating while still respecting users who put in serious time.

8. Research Basis

This project is based on research from habit formation, motivation theory, digital behavior change, and reading behavior.

Key research themes:

People are more likely to maintain behaviors when goals are small and clear.

Self-monitoring helps users recognize progress.

Prompts and cues help users return to the behavior.

Autonomy supports motivation.

Relatedness supports motivation.

Positive reinforcement helps habit formation.

Social accountability can improve engagement when it feels supportive.

Gamification can improve return behavior when it supports the core activity.

Reading apps should avoid rewarding only raw quantity because reading quality and format differ widely.

The product should continue to collect research as development progresses.

All major feature decisions should eventually include:

Research source

Design implication

Risk

Success metric

9. Technical Setup

The first version should be built as a mobile-first web application.

Recommended stack:

Next.js for the frontend

Supabase for authentication, database, storage, and row-level security

PostgreSQL as the main relational database through Supabase

Vercel for deployment

OpenAI API for AI-generated prompts and review assistance

Resend for email reminders

PostHog for product analytics

Tailwind CSS for styling

TypeScript for safer development

Reason:

This stack is fast to build with, easy to deploy, and strong enough for a real MVP. It avoids the complexity of building native iOS and Android apps before the concept is validated.

10. Website vs Mobile App Decision

The first version should be a website, not a native mobile app.

The website should be designed mobile-first and later converted into a Progressive Web App.

Reasons to start with a website:

Faster development

Lower cost

Easier testing

Easier updates

No App Store approval process

Easier sharing with friends

Strong compatibility with Next.js and Supabase

A native app can come later if users show strong weekly engagement and ask for mobile-specific features.

Future app features may include:

Push notifications

Home screen widgets

Offline check-ins

Camera book scanning

Mobile reading reminders

Native animations

If a mobile app becomes necessary, React Native with Expo is the recommended path.

11. MVP Scope

The minimum viable product should prove the core habit loop.

MVP features:

User account creation

Private groups

Add current book

Log reading progress

Monday and Thursday check-ins

AI-generated reflection questions

Group feed

Discussion posts

Replies

Basic streaks

Basic XP

Book completion

Final review

Book nomination

Simple leaderboard

The MVP should not include every long-term feature.

Postpone:

Advanced achievements

Full Book of the Month algorithm

Custom avatars

Reading pets

Reading Wrapped

Kindle integration

Goodreads import

Public communities

Native mobile app

Advanced recommendation engine

Reason:

The MVP should validate whether users actually return to log reading and discuss books with friends.

12. Data Model Overview

Initial database tables may include:

users

profiles

groups

group_members

books

user_books

reading_logs

discussion_prompts

discussion_posts

comments

reviews

review_sections

book_nominations

book_votes

xp_events

momentum_scores

achievements

user_achievements

notifications

This structure keeps the app flexible. It separates books, user progress, social activity, scoring, and reviews.

13. AI Feature Guidelines

AI should support reading, not replace it.

Approved AI uses:

Generate reflection prompts

Generate spoiler-safe discussion questions

Help users draft reviews from their own notes

Summarize personal reading activity

Recommend books based on user preferences

Generate Book of the Month finalist explanations

Avoid:

Generating fake reviews

Answering prompts for users

Creating summaries that let users skip reading

Showing spoilers without warning

Replacing human discussion

AI should always ask, guide, or organize. It should not become the reader.

14. User Experience Direction

The app should feel calm, warm, and motivating.

Design goals:

Simple dashboard

Fast check-ins

Clear reading progress

Encouraging language

Low-pressure reminders

Mobile-first layout

Clean typography

Minimal clutter

Visible group activity

Strong spoiler protection

The product should feel closer to a personal reading space than a competitive productivity tracker.

15. Notification Strategy

Notifications should help users return to reading, not overwhelm them.

Recommended notifications:

Monday check-in reminder

Thursday discussion reminder

Friend replied to your post

Friend finished a book

Book of the Month voting opened

Weekly recap ready

Avoid:

Constant streak pressure

Multiple reminders per day

Guilt-based wording

Aggressive push notifications

Reason:

Too many notifications can make the app feel stressful. The goal is helpful accountability.

16. Success Metrics

The product should measure whether it increases reading behavior.

Important metrics:

Weekly active users

Weekly reading check-ins per user

Discussion participation rate

Average streak length

Book completion rate

Review completion rate

Group retention

Percentage of users returning after missing a week

Average number of replies per discussion post

Book nominations per group

Avoid optimizing only for:

Time spent in app

Number of screens viewed

Number of notifications opened

Reason:

The app should create reading behavior, not just app usage.

17. Development Roadmap

Phase 1: Foundation

Build authentication, profiles, groups, current books, and reading logs.

Phase 2: Habit Loop

Build check-ins, streaks, basic XP, and weekly reminders.

Phase 3: Social Reading

Build discussion posts, replies, group feed, and reactions.

Phase 4: AI Prompts

Build AI-generated questions, prompt history, and spoiler-aware prompt design.

Phase 5: Reviews

Build live reviews, final reviews, category ratings, and review timelines.

Phase 6: Fair Scoring

Build Reading Momentum, XP events, achievement tracking, and leaderboards.

Phase 7: Book of the Month

Build nominations, voting, finalists, and optional group reading.

Phase 8: Polish

Improve UI, onboarding, accessibility, analytics, notifications, and PWA support.

Phase 9: Native App Evaluation

Only consider a native mobile app after proving weekly retention.

18. Risks and Design Concerns

Risk: Users may fake reading logs.

Mitigation:

Focus rewards on consistency, reflection, and discussion rather than only pages.

Risk: Users may feel judged.

Mitigation:

Avoid page-based leaderboards and shame-based notifications.

Risk: AI may generate generic prompts.

Mitigation:

Use book title, genre, progress, and user notes to personalize prompts.

Risk: Users may stop after the novelty wears off.

Mitigation:

Use weekly rituals, group accountability, and visible progress.

Risk: The product may become too complex.

Mitigation:

Build the MVP around one core loop before adding advanced features.

Risk: Spoilers may reduce trust.

Mitigation:

Use progress-based visibility and clear spoiler labels.

19. Documentation Structure

The project should maintain a docs folder.

Recommended structure:

01_Vision.md

02_Product_Principles.md

03_Research.md

04_Features.md

05_Scoring_System.md

06_Data_Model.md

07_AI_Guidelines.md

08_UI_UX.md

09_Roadmap.md

10_Backlog.md

11_Decisions.md

The decisions document should record major product choices.

Each decision should include:

Date

Decision

Reason

Alternatives considered

Research support

Future review date

This will help keep the project organized as it grows.

20. Final Product Goal

Reading Momentum should help users become the type of person who reads consistently.

The platform should not pressure users into finishing books as fast as possible. It should help users build a sustainable relationship with reading through personal choice, small habits, thoughtful reflection, and supportive friends.

The final product should be able to answer one question clearly:

Did this app help someone keep reading when they otherwise would have stopped?

If the answer is yes, the product is succeeding.